



UNIVERSITY OF AMSTERDAM
Amsterdam Business School

MScBA: Ethics and the Future of Business

SESSION 1: MORALS & ETHICS

Arno Kourula – 31 August 2026



Photo by NASA/Bill Anders - www.hq.nasa.gov/office/pao/History/alsj/a410/AS8-14-2383HR.jpg

432 ppm of CO₂ in
atmosphere
(NASA Carbon Dioxide - Earth
Indicator June 2026)

Our economy
consumes 100+ billion
tons of materials every
year. It is 6.9% circular
(€25 trillion lost value)
(Circularity Gap Report
2025 & 2026)

69 of 100 largest
economic entities are
corporations
(World Economic Forum 2016)

The world's richest
1% own 43% of all
global financial
assets
(Oxfam 2024)

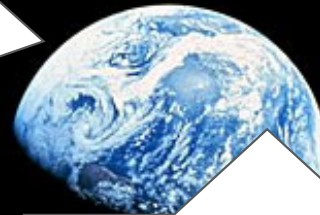
There are 8.3
billion of us on
earth
(World Population Clock 2026)

\$30.3 trillion is
invested globally in
sustainable investing
assets (GSIA, 2022)

96% of the world's
largest 250 companies
produce sustainability
reports
(KPMG 2024)

In 2018, more CEOs
were fired for ethical
lapses rather than
financial challenges or
board conflicts
(PWC 2019)

We are in the middle
of a debate on how
the European Union
should regulate
corporate
sustainability.





Ethics, Responsibility and Sustainability at ABS

Values of ABS:

- **Responsible**, **Critical Thinking**, Analytical, **Engaged**, International.

Vision and focal areas of ABS:

- Responsible digital transformation, welfare and healthcare, resilient society and financial stability, sustainability and environmental economics, and nudging for a better world.

Research:

- Strong research tradition (80+ researchers) and central positioning on the topic.

Teaching:

- Integration into curricula; dedicated courses at bachelor, master, MBA and several electives (70 courses); [Honours Programme Sustainability](#).

Website:

- See: [ABS Ethics, Responsibility and Sustainability](#) and [UvA Sustainability](#).

Question:

- Are management theories amoral, apolitical, and value-free?



Network for
Business Sustainability

Logo source: nbs.net



Principles for Responsible
Management Education

Logo source: www.unprme.org

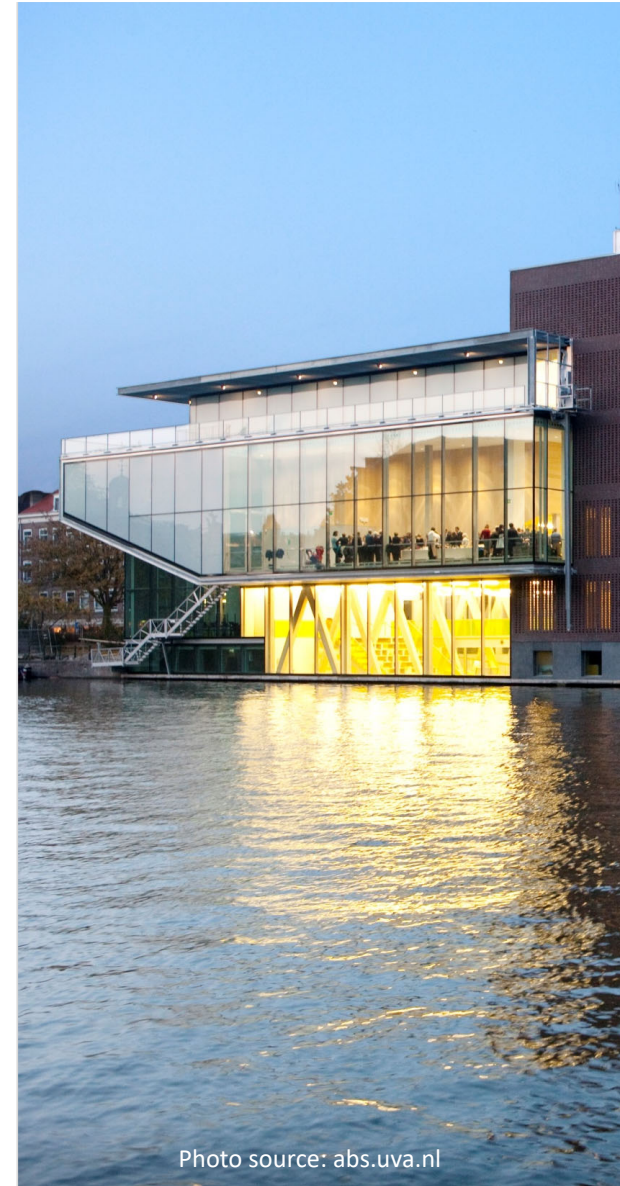


Photo source: abs.uva.nl



UNIVERSITY OF AMSTERDAM
Amsterdam Business School

How to apply to either Honours programme

You can apply to either one of the Honours programmes by completing scanning the QR-code and filling in the application form. At the end of the form you also need to submit:

- Your academic transcripts
- Your CV (one A4 max.)
- Your letter of motivation (one A4 max.)
- An instructor's letter of recommendation remarking on your academic excellence.

Application deadline **10 September 2026**

Honours Programmes Sustainability or Data-Driven Management Application Form



Course objectives

1. Understand, evaluate, and criticize core **ethical theories** and models of ethical decision-making;
2. reflect and improve their own decision-making towards **value-based and stakeholder** approaches;
3. explain and criticize leading concepts and theories within **corporate responsibility and sustainability**;
4. learn and analyze key ethics and sustainability themes within your **chosen specialization**;
5. reflect and **apply learned concepts** and theories to social and environmental issues that organizations face;
6. understand, discuss, and critically reflect on the **ethical and appropriate use of AI** in group work and its communication.



Photo source: www.pexels.com/photo/archery-rising-objectives-260627/

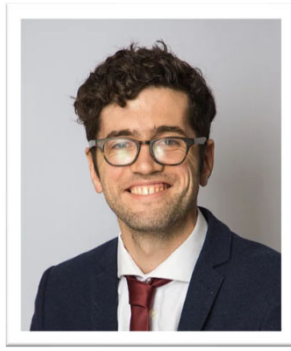


UNIVERSITY OF AMSTERDAM
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Lecturer team



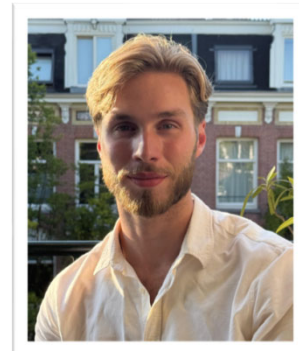
Arad Ahi



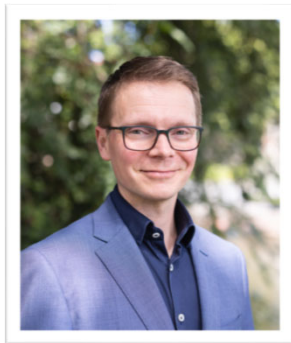
Kevin Curran



Willemijn van Dolen



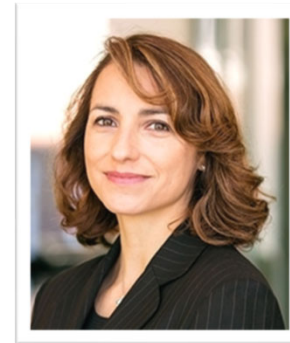
David 't Hart
(Teaching assistant)



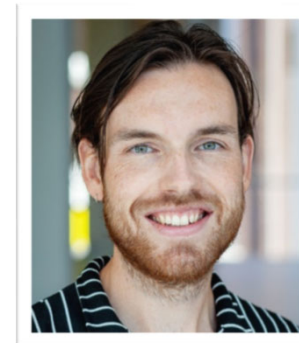
Arno Kourula
(Course coordinator)



Richard Ronay



Michelle
Westermann-Behaylo



Hendrik
de With



Introduction to lecturer (General part)

Arno Kourula

Professor of Business and Sustainability

Head of Strategy and International Business section

Director of Ethics, Responsibility and Sustainability

Academic: Aalto University (D.Sc. Econ. 2009, M.Sc. Econ. 2003), Stanford University, and Copenhagen Business School.

Research focus: Corporate sustainability and cross-sector interaction.

Teaching: Courses and supervision in corporate sustainability and ethics.

Collaborations: Amsterdam University Medical Center, City of Amsterdam, City of Helsinki, Google, Kesko, KPMG, Ministry for Foreign Affairs of Finland, Netherlands Enterprise Agency, Nokia, Save the Children, Stora Enso, Unilever, United Nations, US Department of Energy, VodafoneZiggo, several startups and scaleups.

Contact: A.E.Kourula@uva.nl; LinkedIn: www.uva.nl/en/profile/a.e.kourula



Agenda for today

1. Course practicalities
2. Introduction to business ethics
3. Normative theories of ethics
4. Recap



Photo by Geran de Klerk on Unsplash

1. Course practicalities

Photo source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Peraldus_Vices_and_Virtues.jpg





Course [Canvas site](#)

≡ 6314M0507Y > Syllabus

2026/27 Sem. 1, per. 1

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Recent Announcements



To students who follow the “Management of International Business and Trade” track

Dear students, If you follow the “Management of Internationala...

[↩ Reply](#)



Welcome to the course **Ethics and the Future of Business!**

Dear Ethics and the Future of Business course participants, ...

[↩ Reply](#)

Ethics and the Future of Business

Welcome to the course **Ethics and the Future of Business!**



Course structure

General part:

- Lectures common for all MScBA tracks.
- Themes: Morals & Ethics; Behaviors & Actions; Strategies & Stakeholders; Challenges & Solutions.
- 2 x 2h per week in late August / early September.

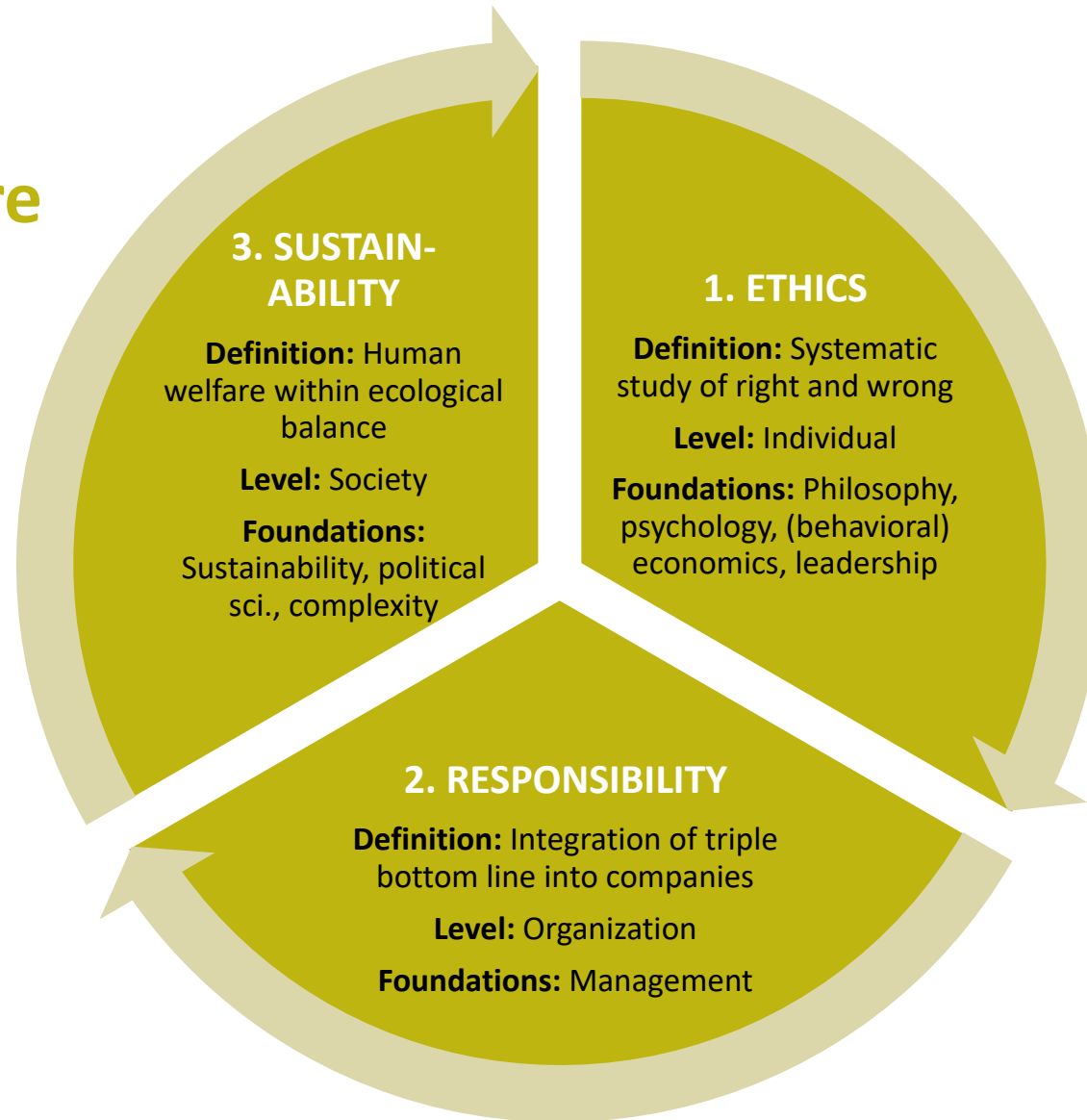
Track-specific part:

- Tailored content for each track/group: 1) Consumer & Digital Marketing, 2) Strategy and AI Transformation, 3) International Business, 4) Entrepreneurship and Management in the Creative Industries, 5) Entrepreneurship and Innovation, 6) Leadership & Management, and 7) Strategy.
- 2 x 2h per week in late September / early October.



Photo by Alvaro Pinot on Unsplash

Course structure



Course assessment

The final grade consists of:

Individual exam (general part):

- 70% of final grade.
- Mix of multiple choice, definitions, and open questions.
- Materials: General session readings and slides.
- Reflection questions and sample exam on Canvas (“Modules”).
- Wed 23 September 23, 19:00-21:00, in person (see rooster.uva.nl).

Group assignments (track-specific part):

- 20% of final grade for assignment.
- 10% of final grade for AI ethical reflection related to assignment.
- Video assignment.
- Materials and instructions: To be discussed in track-specific sessions, including AI policy, and later available in “Modules”.
- Submission via Canvas by Fri 23 October, 8:00 (Amsterdam time).

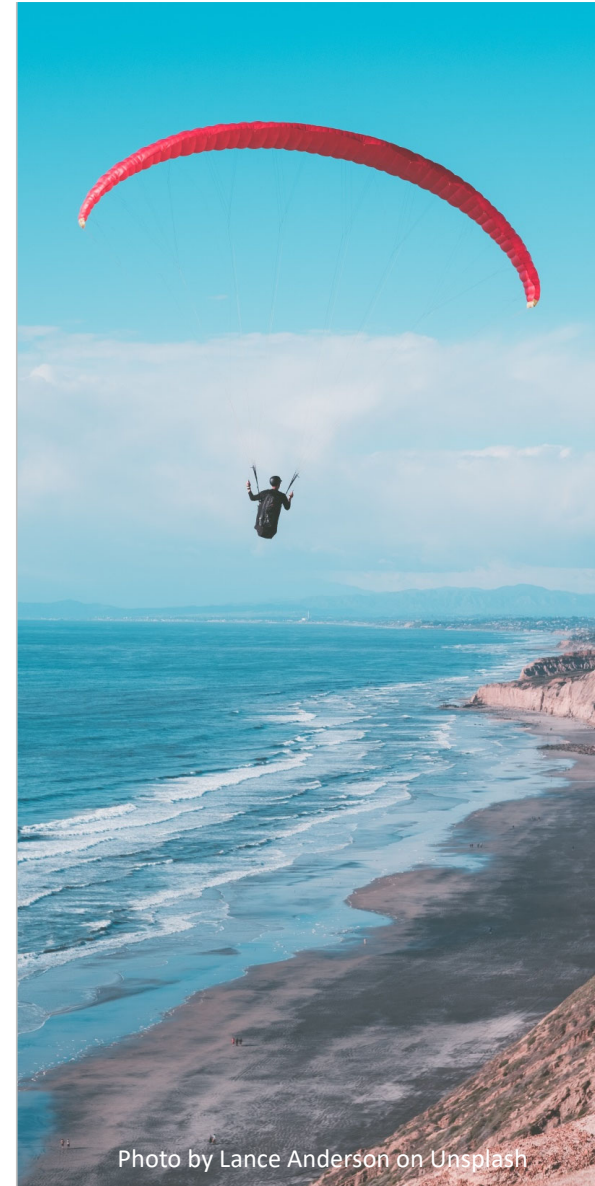


Photo by Lance Anderson on Unsplash

2. Introduction to business ethics

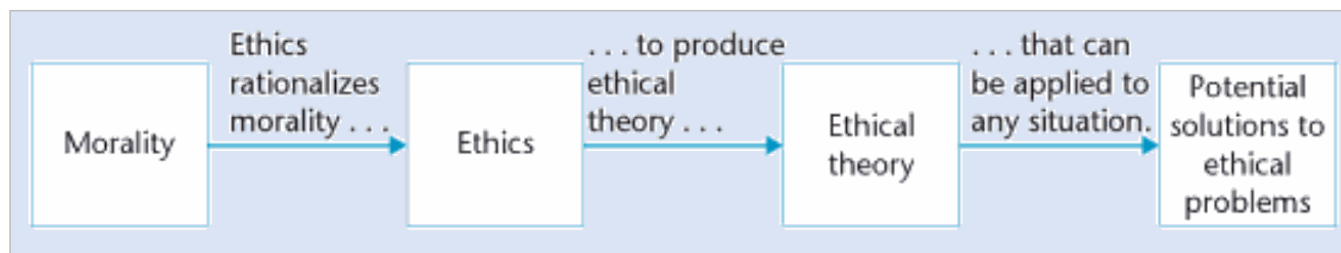
Source:

[https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/6f/Ariuna and His Charioteer Krishna Confront Karna.jpg](https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/6f/Ariuna_and_His_Charioteer_Krishna_Confront_Karna.jpg)



Morality, ethics, and ethical theory

- **Morality** is humans' ability to distinguish between right and wrong.
- **Ethics** is the systematic study of morality.
- **Ethical theories** are principles and rules that determine right and wrong in different situations.
- Today we focus on **normative ethics**, i.e. the study of how we ought to behave.



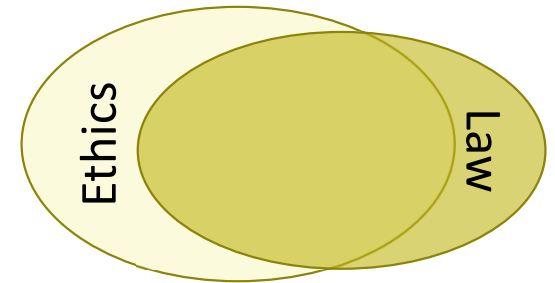
(Source: Crane, A. & Matten, D. 2010. Business ethics: managing corporate citizenship and sustainability in the age of globalization (3rd ed.). Oxford University Press.)

Ethics

- An on-going discussion about morality with a **very long history**.
- Ethics typically examines right and wrong from the **perspective of a human being** (anthropocentric), instead of, for instance, nature.
- Key **questions** include:
 1. What kind of moral principles should guide our actions?
 2. What kind of outcomes should we aim for?
- Ethics is not just theorization of morals, but the aim is also to affect **practice**.
- Ethical theories can give **contradictory solutions** to the same problem.
- **Business ethics** is the study of business situations, activities, and decisions where issues of right and wrong are addressed.

Do we need ethics when we have the law?

- In society, morality is the foundation of the law.
- Law and ethics are partly overlapping.
Nonetheless:
 1. The law does not cover all ethical issues (e.g. cheating on your partner).
 2. Not all legal issues are ethical (e.g. driving on the right side of the road).
 3. Law and ethics can involve contradictions (e.g. Apartheid).
- The road from unethical to illegal is short and slippery.
- Companies can operate in locations with lacking legal infrastructure.

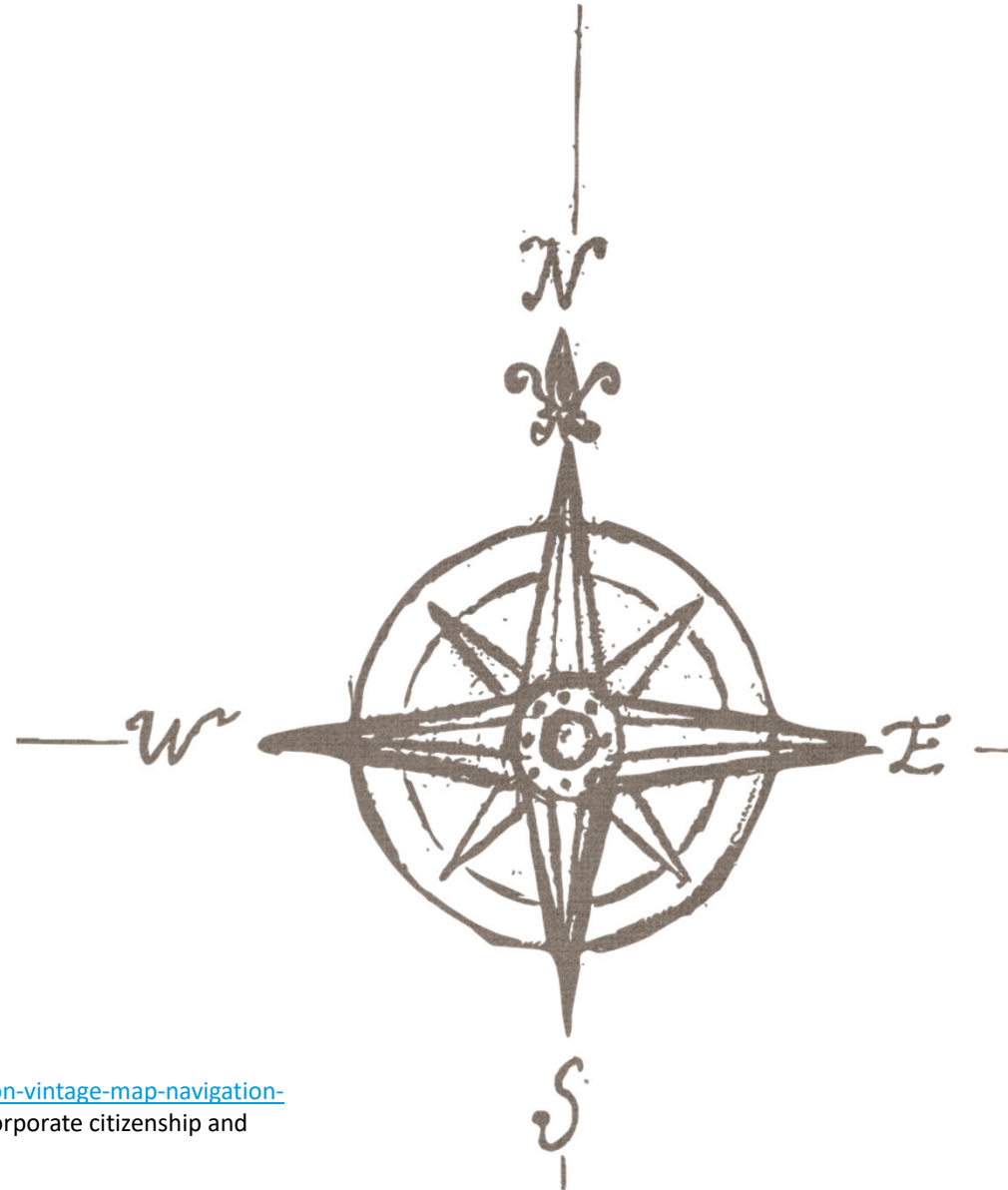


Moral orientations

Which moral principle do you think is the best to distinguish right from wrong:

- Follow the moral guidance of your religion.
- Follow your conscience.
- Aim at your own benefit.
- Do your duty.
- Respect yourself and others.
- Do not violate human rights.
- Support the common good.
- Act with fairness and justice.
- Be a good person.

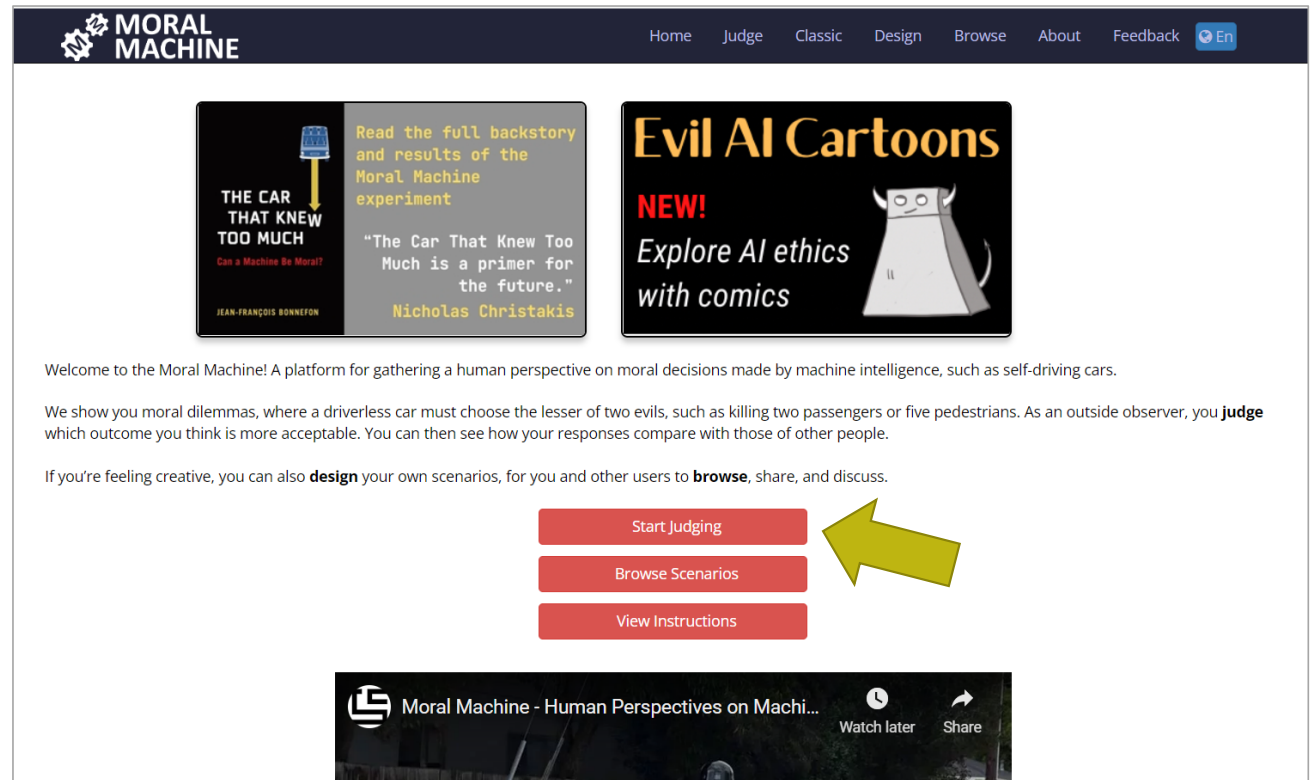
Picture source: <https://www.needpix.com/photo/648242/compass-north-south-direction-vintage-map-navigation-exploration-journey/> Source: Crane, A. & Matten, D. 2010. Business ethics: managing corporate citizenship and sustainability in the age of globalization (3rd ed.). Oxford University Press.



Case: Moral machine

Website:

www.moralmachine.net

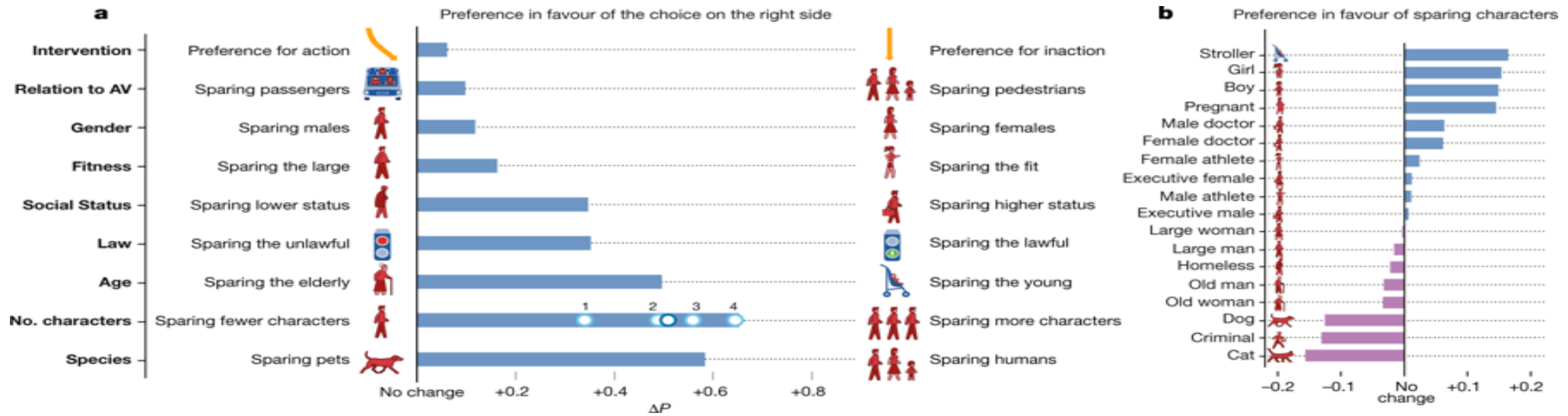


Trolley dilemma

Eleanor Nelsen: “Would you sacrifice one person to save five”?

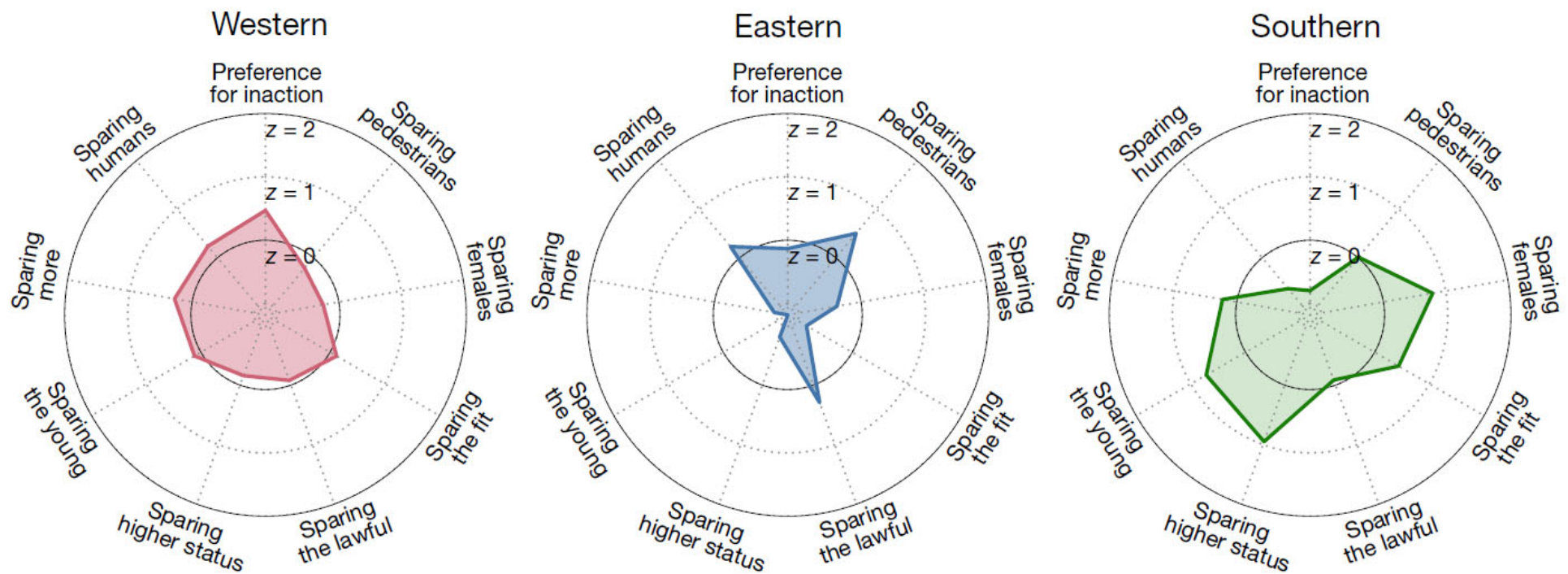


Moral machine: Preferences



Source: Awad, E., et al. 2018. The Moral Machine experiment. Nature, 563, 59-64.

Moral machine: Culture



Source: Awad, E., et al. 2018. The Moral Machine experiment. Nature, 563, 59-64.

Nine ways to cross (Narayan, 2026)

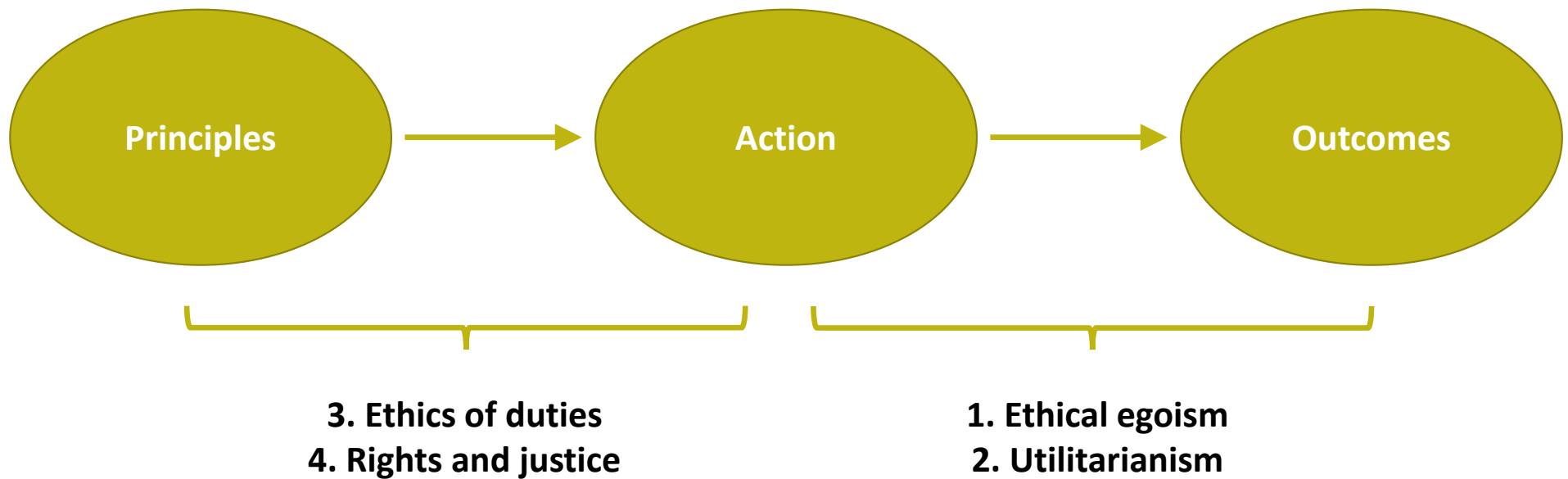
	RULE - BASED	OUTCOME - BASED	CHARACTER / RELATIONAL
AUTONOMOUS INDIVIDUAL	Kantian Deontology Western · Enlightenment	Utilitarian Calculus Western · Consequentialism	Virtue Ethics Western · Aristotelian
SITUATED IN CONTEXT	Dharma–Svadharmā (धर्म) Indian · Dharmaśāstra / Gītā	Pragmatism Western · Dewey & James	Daoist Wú Wéi (無為) Chinese · Daoist Tradition
INTERDEPENDENT NETWORK	Confucian Lǐ (禮) Chinese · Ruist Tradition	Ubuntu (ùmùntù) African · Nguni / Bantu	Pratītyasamutpāda (शून्यता) Indian · Mādhyamika

Columns: How is order governed? **Rows:** What is the moral agent?

3. Normative ethical theories

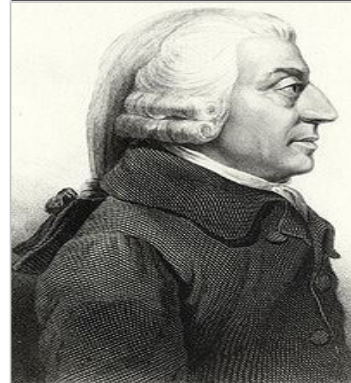
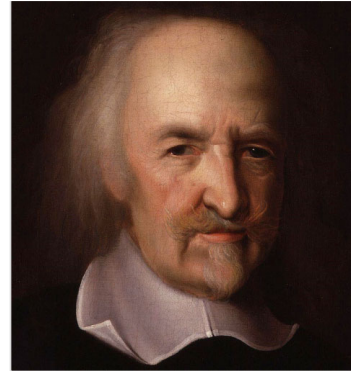


Principles vs. outcomes



Perspective 1: Ethical egoism

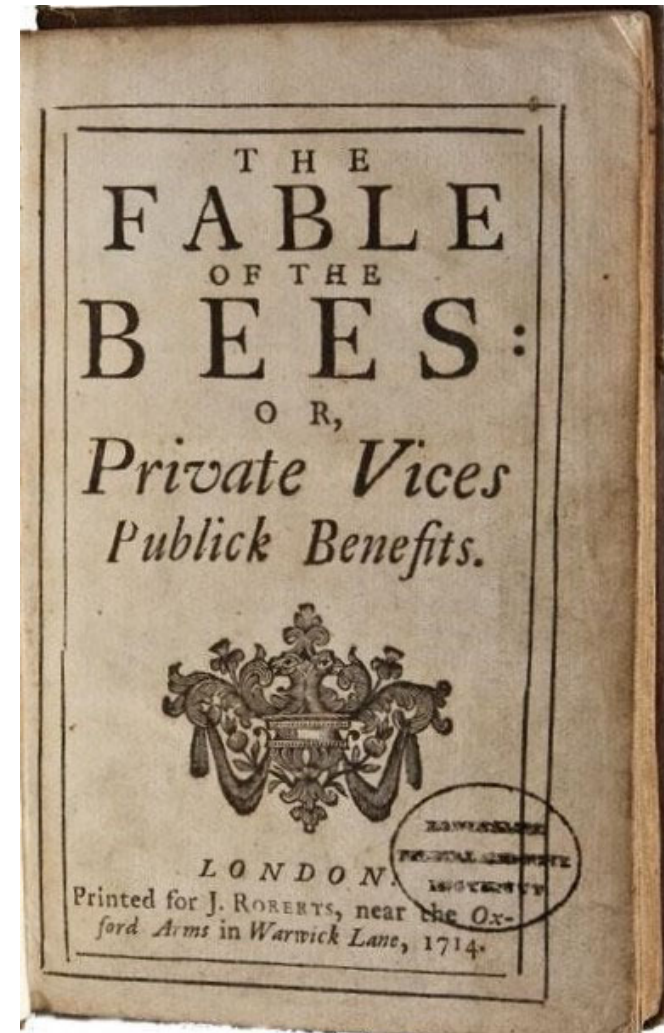
- Usually **not considered as an ethical theory**, although this view is very influential in economics.
- An action is morally right if the decision-maker freely decides in order to pursue either their (short-term) **desires** or their (long-term) **interests**.
- Authors: Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679), Adam Smith (1723-1790), popularized by Ayn Rand (1905-1982).
- The influence of egoism is related to the perception of ideal markets and (a limited reading of) **Adam Smith's "invisible hand"**:
 - "It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer, or the baker that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own interest." (Smith 1776)



Picture sources: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Thomas_Hobbes#/media/File:Thomas_Hobbes_\(portrait\).jpg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Thomas_Hobbes#/media/File:Thomas_Hobbes_(portrait).jpg) / <https://www.biography.com/scholar/adam-smith/> / <https://www.theguardian.com/books/2017/apr/10/new-age-ayn-rand-conquered-trump-white-house-silicon-valley>

Problems with ethical egoism

- Inconsistent as it "condones blatant immoral wrongs, since 'anything goes'-violence against the vulnerable, theft, even murder-as long as the egoist's needs are served" (Crane et al., 2019, 96)
- Thus, a moral view based on short term satisfaction of needs is **contradictory with our moral principles**.
- **Enlightened egoism** focuses on the meeting of long-term human interests.
- Enlightened egoism does not take a stance on the nature of the interests and desires of individuals, which can still lead to problems due to **conflicting interests**.
- Although taking care of your needs and interests is morally important, the theory needs to be **complemented** by more developed ethical theories.



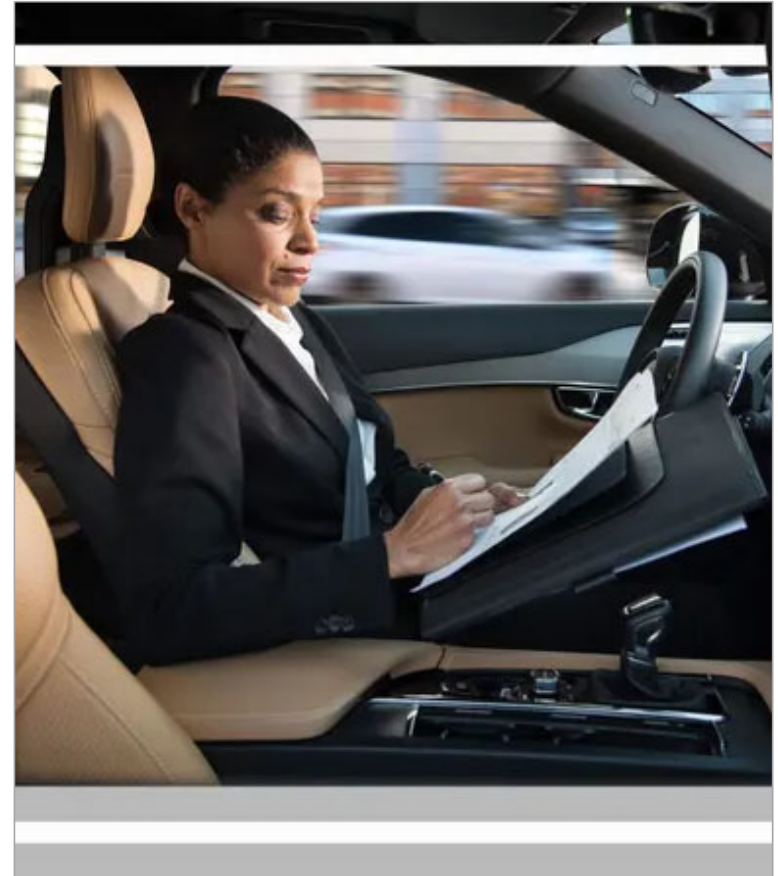
Picture source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Fable_of_the_Bees#/media/File:Fable_of_the_bees.jpg

Application to self-driving car

What would an ethical egoist do?

If an ethical egoist is buying a car, they would protect the people inside the car.

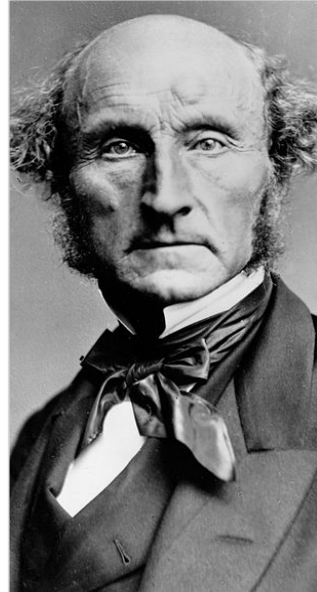
If an ethical egoist is manufacturing the car, they would likely aim to serve egoist customers to sell more cars.



Source: www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/jan/03/peak-hype-driverless-car-revolution-uber-robotaxis-autonomous-vehicle

Theory 2: Utilitarianism

- An act is morally right if it results in the **greatest amount of good to the greatest amount of people** affected by the action.
- Important authors Jeremy **Bentham** (1748-1832) and John Stuart **Mill** (1806-1873).
- Utilitarianism is very **influential** in normative economics, which is related to the egoistic view of humans in economics.
- Egoism in economics tends to function within a **utilitarian societal moral theory**.
- **Act utilitarianism:** Whether a single act is right or wrong depends on the amount of common good it produces.
- **Rule utilitarianism:** Focuses on creating rules that produce the most common good.
- In practice, utilitarianism becomes an analysis of advantages and disadvantages, a **cost/benefit analysis**.



Picture sources: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Jeremy_Bentham_by_Henry_William_Pickersgill.jpg / https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/John_Stuart_Mill#/media/File:John_Stuart_Mill_by_London_Stereoscopic_Company,_c1870.jpg

Problems of utilitarianism

- A utilitarian good is **subjective**, context-dependent, and difficult to compare between people.
- Utilitarianism runs into difficulties in questions related to the just **distribution of wealth**.
- Utilitarianism can be contradictory with the idea of respecting **basic rights**.
- **Maximizing** is generally speaking not the best approach to addressing all values.
- Utilitarianism does not include the idea of **reciprocity**.

Picture source: <https://de.wikipedia.org/wiki/Panopticon#/media/Datei:Presidio-modelo2.JPG>

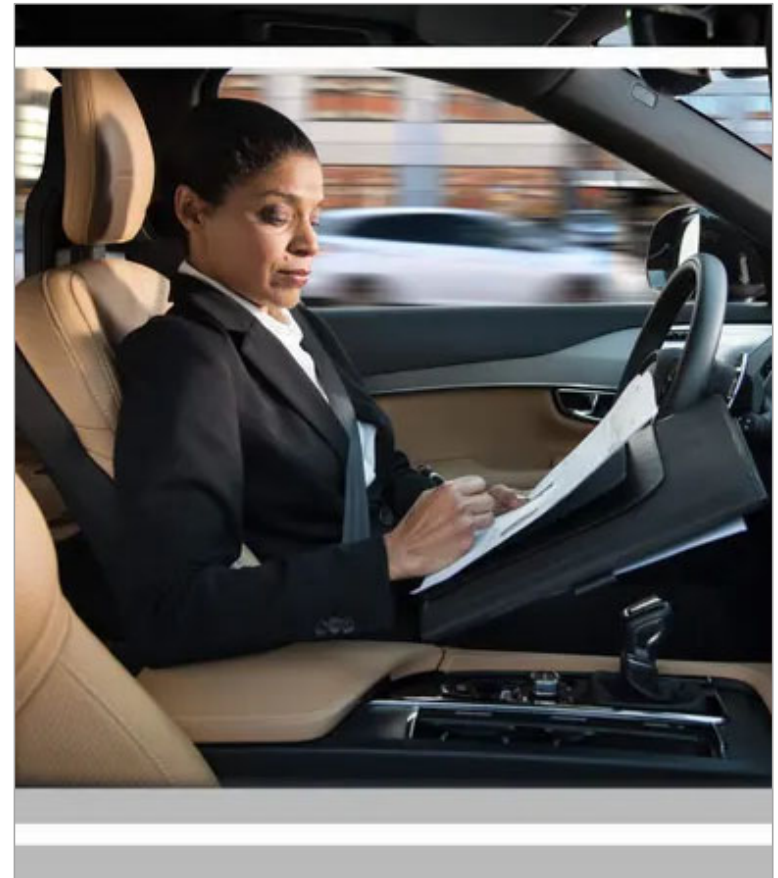


Application to self-driving car

What would a utilitarian do?

According to act utilitarianism, you should conduct a cost/benefit analysis of what causes the most benefit or least harm in each situation. A utilitarian would aim to harm as few as possible.

According to rule utilitarianism, self-driving vehicles should minimize casualties. They should be introduced only if they are likely to make driving in general safer.



Source: www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/jan/03/peak-hype-driverless-car-revolution-uber-robotaxis-autonomous-vehicle

Theory 3: Ethics of duties

- Most famous author: Immanuel **Kant** (1724-1804).
- Central concepts to Kant's moral philosophy are duty, consistency, dignity, and universality.
- Duties do not mean mechanistically following rules, but they involve **human's ability** to develop moral law and moral rules.
- Kant's deontological theory develops principles or **categorical imperatives** to guide our actions.



Picture source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Immanuel_Kant

Ethics of duties: Categorical imperatives

Univereal applicability

- **Categorical imperative:** "act only so that the will through its maxims could regard itself at the same time as universally lawgiving."
- **Main idea:** Check that the principle is acceptable to every human being (e.g., tomorrow's newspaper test).

Respect for persons

- **Categorical imperative:** "act so that you treat humanity, whether in your own person or in that of another, always as an end and never as a means only".
- **Main idea:** A human being is a valuable autonoomical being, and not a means to an end or a tool.



Picture source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Immanuel_Kant

Problems with ethics of duties

- Ethics of duties is a rather difficult and **abstract theory**.
- Morality can be seen as a **heavy burden** to bear.
- Morality is founded perhaps too strictly on the **use of reason**.
- Ethics of duties **undervalues outcomes** of actions.



Picture source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Immanuel_Kant

Application to self-driving car

What would someone following ethics of duties do?

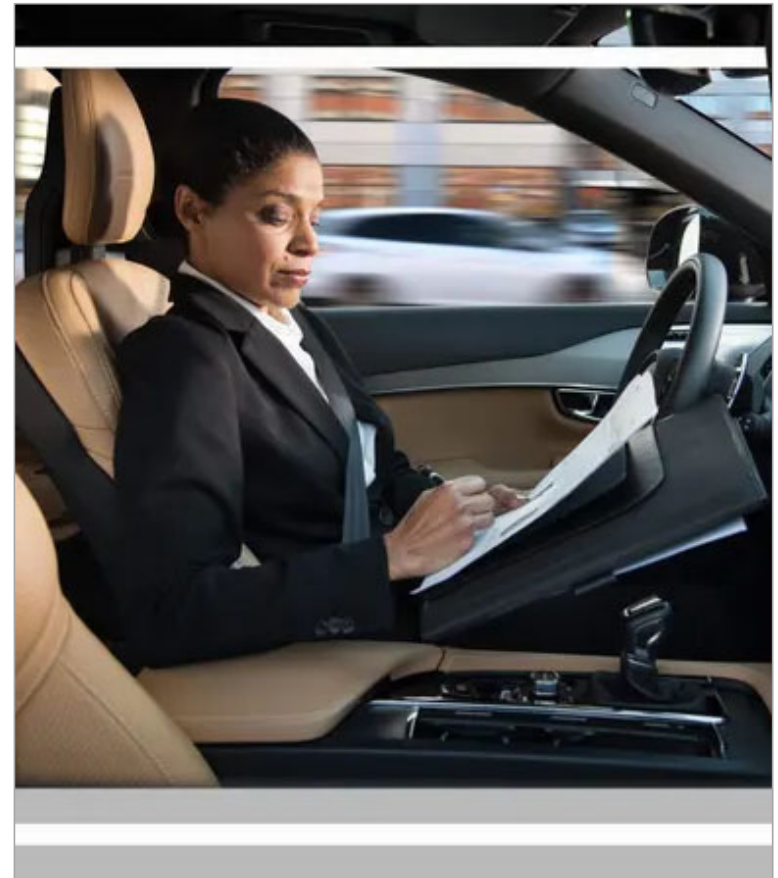
We should determine general rules that apply to all.

For example, if the owner of the car is seen as responsible for the consequences of it, then the persons inside the car should be sacrificed.

Rule example: The one who generates mobility risks cannot sacrifice non-involved individuals.

Rules have to be accepted by all.

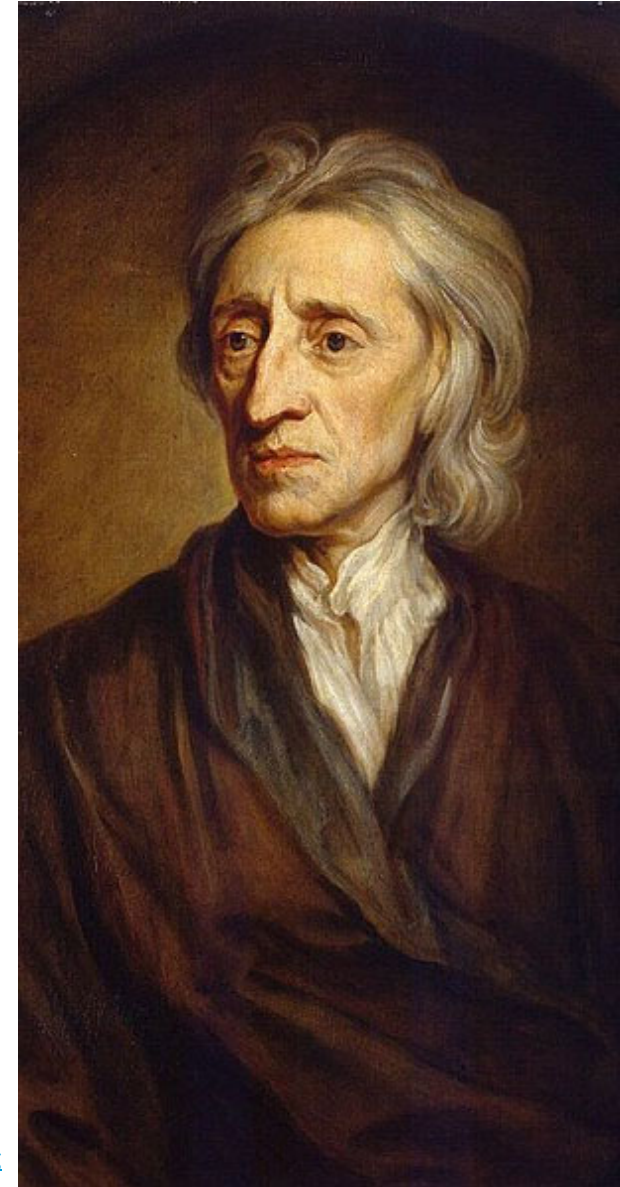
→ Human moral reasoning should be central.



Source: www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/jan/03/peak-hype-driverless-car-revolution-uber-robotaxis-autonomous-vehicle

Theory 4: Rights & justice

- **Natural (human) rights** are certain basic, important, inalienable entitlements that should be respected and protected in every single situation. These are based in **human dignity** and lead to a duty for others to protect, respect, and support them.
- **Main natural rights:** Right to life, freedom, property, speech, privacy, conscience, and fair trial among others.
- Central authors: John **Locke** (1632-1714) and John **Rawls** (1921-2002).
- Rights-based thinking are a central part of **Western political and ethical thought** and the foundation of **universal human rights**.
- **Justice:** The simultaneous fair treatment of individuals in a given situation with the result that everybody gets what they deserve.
- **Key ideas:** Procedural vs. distributive fairness; veil of ignorance; social contract; system of basic liberties, judgement of society by the state of the least advantaged, and equal opportunity.



Picture source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:John_Locke.jpg

Problems with rights & justice

- Most lists of basic rights can be seen to be relatively **arbitrary**. Rights are criticized as being **too Western** and/or neocolonial.
- Basic rights presuppose **institutions** that allow for recourse in case of breach. Theory does not offer practical guidance in extreme situations.



Eleanor Roosevelt, civil and human rights advocate

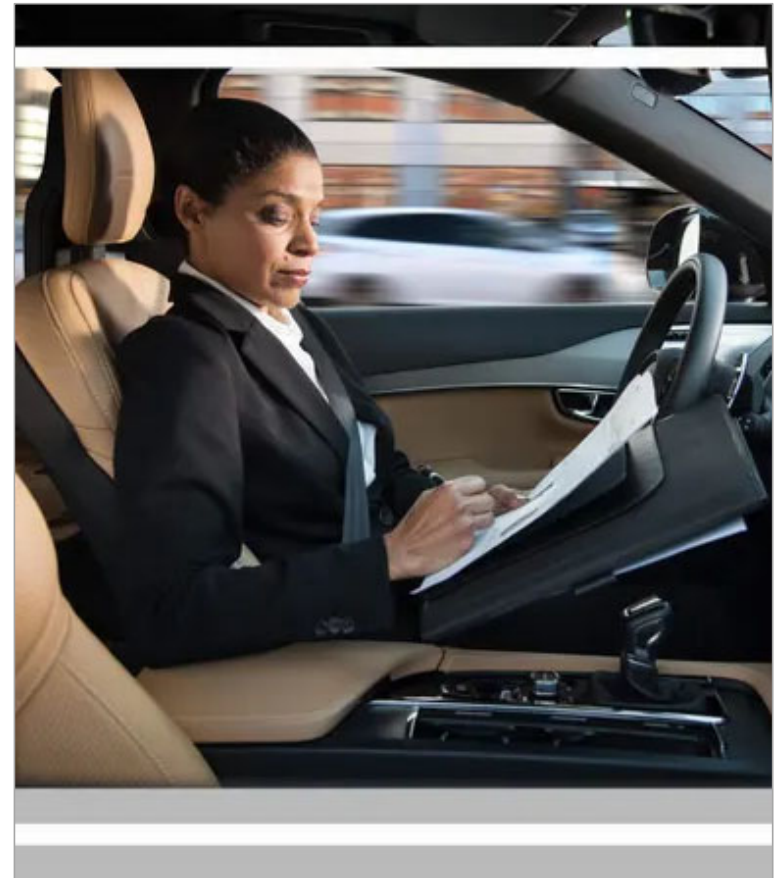
Picture source: https://cs.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Soubor:Eleanor_Roosevelt_-_NARA_-_195319.jpg

Application to self-driving car

What would someone following a rights and justice perspective do?

We can neither discriminate by age, gender, physical appearance or status, nor can we take someone's life for crossing on a red light.

From a justice perspective, the entire traffic systems needs to be fair in considering e.g., those who cannot afford a car and that individuals should e.g., not be able to change settings to protect themselves.



Source: www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/jan/03/peak-hype-driverless-car-revolution-uber-robotaxis-autonomous-vehicle

Alternative perspectives on ethics

Virtue ethics

- The central aim is not to fulfill duties or aim for the greatest good, but to lead a good life. Virtue ethics focuses on the character of the individual decision-maker.
- Authors: Aristotle & Alasdair MacIntyre.

Feminist ethics

- Instead of abstract moral principles, feminist ethics emphasizes caring, empathy, and harmonious and healthy social relationships.
- Authors: Carol Gilligan & Virginia Held.

Discourse ethics

- Discourse ethics focuses on solving ethical conflicts through democratic dialogue and providing a process of norm generation.
- Author: Jürgen Habermas

Postmodern ethics

- Moving away from rationality, postmodern ethics focuses on emotional moral impulses towards others, and focuses on individual questioning of universal rules.
- Author: Zygmunt Bauman & Emmanuel Levinas



Consideration	Typical question you might ask yourself	Theory
One's own interests	Is this really in my, or my organization's, best long-term interests? Would it be acceptable and expected for me to think only of the consequences to myself in this situation?	Egoism
Social consequences	If I consider all of the possible consequences of my actions, for everyone that is affected, will we be better or worse off overall? How likely are these consequences and how significant are they?	Utilitarianism
Duties to others	Who do I have obligations to in this situation? What would happen if everybody acted in the same way as me? Am I treating people only to get what I want for myself (or my organization) or am I thinking also of what they might want too?	Ethics of duty
Entitlements of others	Whose rights do I need to consider here? Am I respecting fundamental human rights and people's need for dignity?	Ethics of rights
Fairness	Am I treating everyone fairly here? Have processes been set up to allow everyone an equal chance? Are there major disparities between the 'winners' and 'losers' that could be avoided?	Theories of justice
Moral character	Am I acting with integrity here? What would a decent, honest person do in the same situation?	Virtue ethics
Care for others and relationships	How do (or would) the other affected parties feel in this situation? Can I avoid doing harm to others? Which solution is most likely to preserve healthy and harmonious relationships among those involved?	Feminist ethics
Process of resolving conflicts	What norms can we work out together to provide a mutually acceptable solution to this problem? How can we achieve a peaceful settlement of this conflict that avoids 'railroading' by the most powerful player?	Discourse ethics
Moral impulse and emotions	Am I simply going along with the usual practice here, or slavishly following the organization's code, without questioning whether it really feels right to me? How can I get closer to those likely to be affected by my decision? What do my emotions or gut feelings tell me once I'm out of the office?	Postmodern ethics

Ethical leadership: Ethics vs. effectiveness (Ciulla 2020)

- The principles vs. outcomes struggle: A **good** leader (a normative concept) is both **ethical** and **effective**.

Problematizations:

- Moral **luck**: Leaders are not in control of everything!
 - Dirty hands problem: Sometimes only **bad options**!
 - Moral **perfection** as an achievable target?
 - **Altruism** as a necessity for leadership?
 - Transformational leadership as strong **values**?
 - Do leaders need to be **charismatic**?
 - From Plato's **philosopher king** to weavers (bringing together different people)?
- A virtue ethical defense of leadership



4. Recap

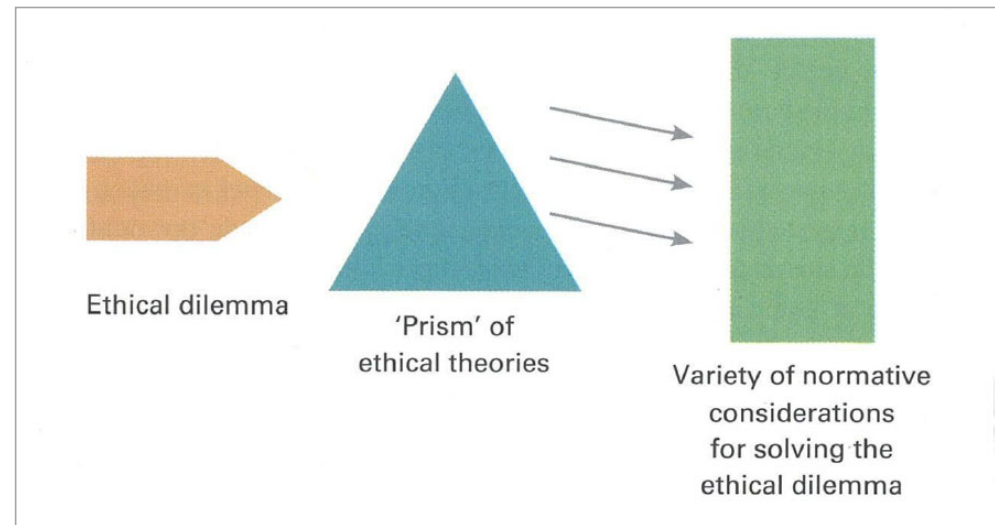
Source:

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Confucius#/media/File:The Classic of Filial Piety \(%E9%96%8B%E5%AE%97%E6%98%8E%E7%BE%A9%E7%AB%A0%E7%95%AB\).jpg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Confucius#/media/File:The_Classic_of_Filial_Piety_(%E9%96%8B%E5%AE%97%E6%98%8E%E7%BE%A9%E7%AB%A0%E7%95%AB).jpg)



Conclusion on using ethical theories

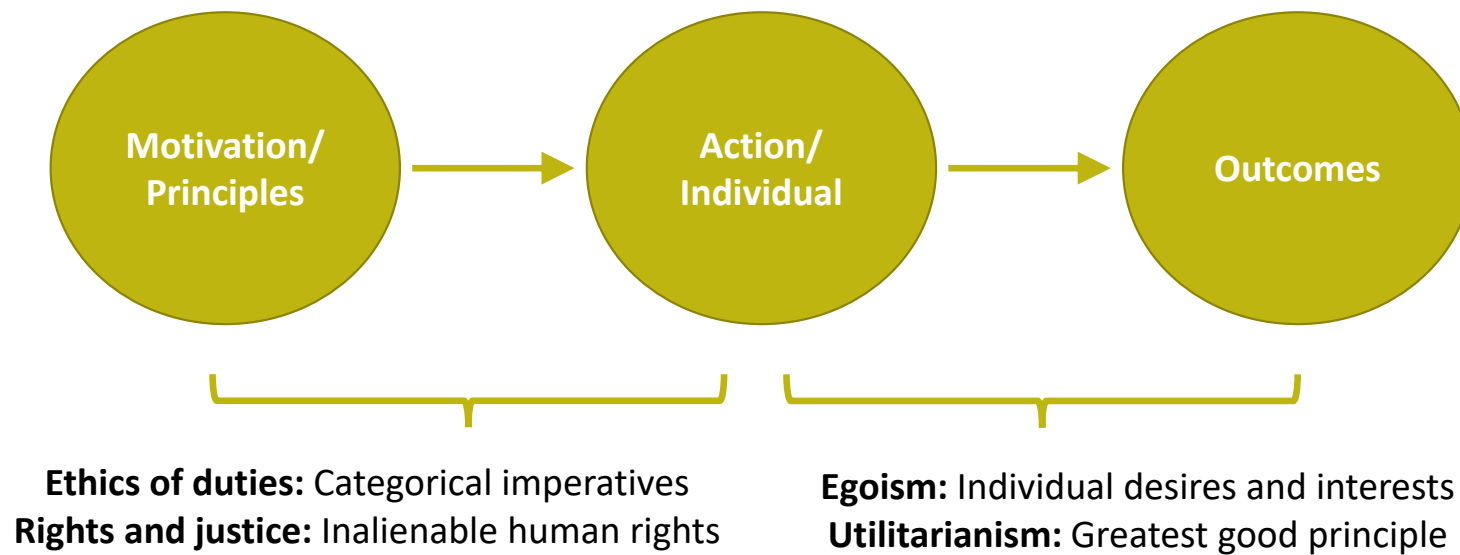
- Crane et al. defend a **pluralistic** view of ethical theories.
- Pluralism represents a **moderate view**.
- Pluralism does not view any single theory as the only correct approach to ethical problems. **Each ethical theory is seen to provide resources** for decision making.
- The aim is to find a contextually appropriate **balance and consensus** that takes into consideration different perspectives.



Crane, A., Matten, D., Glozer, S. & Spence, L. 2019. Business ethics: managing corporate citizenship and sustainability in the age of globalization (5th ed.). Oxford University Press.

Recap

Virtue ethics: Virtuous character
Ethics of care: Care and empathy



Discourse ethics: Democratic dialogue
Postmodern ethics: Moral impulses